

NEW QUEEN ON THE BOARD

Divya Deshmukh beat Koneru Humpy in the final to win the **Women's Chess World Cup** and become India's 88th Grandmaster.

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Indian chess has never had it this good, showcasing its growing prowess with consistency and signalling that the best may still lie ahead.

After five-time World Champion Viswanathan Anand's glorious years, Indian chess is now witnessing success stories like never before. In the past year alone, the country swept gold at the Chess Olympiad, 18-year-old D. Gukesh triumphed at the Candidates Tournament and eventually became World Champion, and now, 19-year-old Divya Deshmukh has stunned the world with her conquest of the Women's World Cup.

The World Cup in Batumi, Georgia, featured a field of 107 players and intense knockout-format battles. The rules tested players' skills across multiple time formats. The elite field included nearly all top players except the reigning World Champion Ju Wenjun.

As it turned out, the final battle for glory was fought between compatriots K. Humpy and Divya. At 38, Humpy had experience that exceeded Divya's age, but

